

Judiciary & Constitutional Bodies

SC/HC jurisdiction, writs, judicial review, EC/CAG/UPSC facts.

Portion focus ~81% · Topic: polity-institutions

PYQ themes: Judicial review · Writs · EC · CAG · UPSC · Finance Commission

Why this portion (PYQ lens)

Portion chance ~81%. Stable yearly; parent polity-institutions ~85%.

Years appeared (synthesis): 2016, 2017, 2018, 2019, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023, 2024, 2025

Why UPSC asks this

Independence safeguards and writ distinctions are perennial.

Syllabus framing

Portion chance ~81%. Stable yearly; parent polity-institutions ~85%. This portion sits inside polity-institutions and centres on higher judiciary and constitutional bodies. Independence safeguards and writ distinctions are perennial.

Recurring PYQ angles: Judicial review, Writs, EC, CAG, UPSC, Finance Commission. Approximate appearance years in the 2016-2025 educational synthesis: 2016, 2017, 2018, 2019, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023, 2024, 2025. Use the chance percentage only to sequence study hours - it is not an official prediction.

Core map of higher judiciary and constitutional bodies

Judicial review: Validity review of legislative/executive action. SC original jurisdiction: Federal disputes sketch.

Appellate jurisdiction: Appeals routes. Advisory jurisdiction: President reference - non-binding tradition.

Hold this core map as your elimination spine before memorising peripheral CA overlays.

Core concepts and definitions

Five writs: Habeas, mandamus, prohibition, certiorari, quo warranto. Art 32 vs 226: SC vs HC writ reach contrasts.

PIL: Access expansion awareness. Appointment debates: Collegium/NJAC headline.

Institutions, processes and mechanisms

EC Art 324: Election superintendence. CAG: Audit watchdog.

UPSC: Recruitment constitutional body. Finance Commission Art 280: Devolution advice.

India angle and applied examples

Constitutional vs statutory: Creation source discriminator. NHRC trap: Statutory - not constitutional.

Removal difficulty: Protects tenure. Basic structure link: Judicial review among essentials.

Comparisons, linkages and discriminators

Tribunals: Specialised adjudication awareness. State EC/SFC: State analogues.

Contempt/independence: Protective doctrines outline. AG office: Related constitutional cast.

India angle

Track appointment/EC CA lightly atop static design.

Question patterns and exam spine

Matching lists and multi-statement questions on higher judiciary and constitutional bodies.

Revision spine: Definitions -> table -> India -> traps for higher judiciary and constitutional bodies.

Eliminate anachronisms and category errors first, then test remaining options against table rows and must-remember triggers.

Trap watch-list (specific)

Avoid: NHRC as constitutional. Avoid: Writ purpose mix. Avoid: Advisory opinions as binding decrees. Avoid: CAG = PAC itself.

Writ sheet

Writ | Cue

Habeas corpus -- Produce person

Mandamus -- Command to act

Prohibition -- Stop lower court

Certiorari -- Quash/transfer

Quo warranto -- By what authority

Common traps

x NHRC as constitutional

x Writ purpose mix

x Advisory opinions as binding decrees

x CAG = PAC itself

Must remember

- 5 writs
- 32 vs 226
- EC/CAG/UPSC/FC
- Statutory != constitutional
- Judicial review

Quick revision checklist

[] Reproduce table

[] 5 must-remembers

[] 3 traps

[] India anchor

[] 10 MCQs

Educational prioritisation heuristic - not an official UPSC prediction. (c) UPSC IAS Study Hub original notes.